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General Education Reflection

While attending Iowa State University, I have had the opportunity to take courses outside my major that have broadened my perspective and contributed to my learning and development as an engineer. In this paper, I will reflect on how the courses POL S 333: Democracy and Diversity in America, HIST 202: Western Civilization II, and HIST 201: Western Civilization I contributed to my problem-solving abilities and technical skills. These courses gave me new angles and strategies that have helped me grow beyond the technical aspects of engineering.

Many of my general education courses aligned with my interest in history and taught me how to examine past events and use the lessons learned to make better decisions in the future. In these classes, I analyzed historical events, developed my own thoughts and opinions, and reflected on different interpretations of the past. We then discussed our perspectives as a class, allowing us to challenge our assumptions and learn from one another. This process relates to engineering because it taught me the importance of evaluating my own decisions, recognizing my own mistakes, and reflecting on both successes and failures. As an engineer, I can apply this reflective approach when evaluating project results and identifying ways to improve solutions. Rather than viewing mistakes as failures, I can use them as opportunities to learn and grow as an engineer.

Another important aspect of these courses was the emphasis on class discussion and debate. These activities strengthened my ability to communicate my ideas, respectfully consider

opposing views, and work together to identify the best solution. I learned that my initial opinion is not always the best one and that listening to others' ideas can lead to better conclusions. This is especially important in engineering, where problem solving often requires collaboration among others. By remaining open to feedback, a group can evaluate different ideas, develop effective solutions to complex problems, and determine the best approach through collaboration.

The classes POLS 333 and HIST 202 both focused on political, economic, and societal aspects of the United States and Western Civilization. These courses helped me understand how historical events influence the world we live in today. In engineering ethics, engineers are encouraged to follow ethical principles and consider the consequences of their decisions. The two courses provided context for why these principles matter and how decisions can affect people and communities in different ways.

A specific topic covered in POLS 333: Diversity and Democracy in America that continues to have a significant impact today is the need for greater diversity and inclusion in engineering. Throughout the coursework, I learned how diversity perspectives have contributed to positive changes in society and can continue to improve. I gained a better understanding of the area where progress is still needed, including the lack of gender diversity within the engineering field. As a result, I have developed a greater appreciation for diversity and a stronger motivation to promote inclusion throughout my engineering career.

These courses also helped me understand how political decisions have long lasting consequences, both positive and negative. Some of the topics covered involved events that occurred many years ago, yet their effects can still be felt today. As an engineer, this opened my eyes to the importance of careful decision making because the choices I make can have significant and lasting impact on society. By reflecting on the successes and failures of the past, I

can make informed decisions and develop engineering solutions that create a positive, lasting impact on the world.

My general education courses have broadened my perspectives and strengthened my problem-solving, critical thinking, and communication skills. By studying the past and engaging in class discussion and debates, I have learned to evaluate problems from different viewpoints and make more informed decisions. These skills will help me grow as an engineer, allowing me to look beyond technical solutions and consider the larger impact of my decisions on society.